Emily Lawson

Curriculum Vitae
2026

Department of Philosophy
University of British Columbia
Vancouver, BC V6T 1Z1

emily.lawson@ubc.ca
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AOS: Philosophy of Mind, Aesthetics, Indian Philosophy
AOC: Buddhist Philosophy, Value Theory

Education

Ph.D.	2022 - 2027	Philosophy, The University of British Columbia, Vancouver, BC (ABD) **Dissertation Title:** "Life's Painful Beauty: *Rasa* and Deathbed Aesthetics" **Committee:** Evan Thompson (primary supervisor) Catherine Prueitt (co-supervisor) and Dominic McIver Lopes (committee member)
MFA	2017 - 2020	Creative Writing: Poetry, The University of Virginia, Charlottesville, VA Thesis Title: *Endlings*
BA	2011 - 2015	Cross-Cultural Philosophy, Hampshire College, Amherst, MA

Publications

Books

Under Contract: *Death: A Guide for Imaginers,* Columbia University Press, 2028. In progress.

Peer-Reviewed Articles

2026 "Abhinavagupta on Savoring Aesthetic Disgust," *Philosophers' Imprint.* Accepted and forthcoming. DOI: https://doi.org/10.3998/phimp.9147

2026 "Deathbed Aesthetics: Ugliness and Courageous Love," *British Journal of Aesthetics.* Accepted and forthcoming. DOI: https://doi.org/10.1093/aesthj/ayag032

2025 "A Dynamic Approach to Compulsive Fantasy: Creativity and Constraint in 'Maladaptive Daydreaming.'" With Jennifer Burrell and Kalina Christoff Hadjiilieva. *Behavioral Sciences* 15(10):1333

2024 "Courageous Love: K. C. Bhattacharyya on the Puzzle of Painful Beauty." With Dominic McIver Lopes. *Journal of the American Philosophical Association* 10 (4): 728-743.

2024 "Daydreaming as Spontaneous Immersive Imagination: A Phenomenological Analysis." With Evan Thompson. *Philosophy and the Mind Sciences* 5 (1): 1-34.

Invited Book Chapters

In preparation "Negative *Rasa*s and the Paradox of Horror." *Contemporary Debates in Aesthetics and Philosophy of Art, 2nd Edition,* Wiley, ed. Brandon Polite, Elizabeth Scarbrough, and Aaron Meskin, 2028.

Forthcoming "Daydreaming." *The Cambridge Handbook of Thought,* Cambridge University Press, ed. Andre Zamani and Kalina Christoff Hadjiilieva, 2027. Under Contract.

Invited Book Reviews

2026 "Review: *The Making of Contemporary Indian Philosophy: Krishnachandra Bhattacharyya*, ed. Daniel Raveh, Elise Coquereau-Saouma, 2023." *Journal of Hindu Studies.*

Selected Literary Journal Publications

2026 *ONLY POEMS* Poet of the Week Feature
2024 *Three Hearts: An Anthology of Cephalopod Poetry,* "Aubade with Deep Sea Footage"
2023 *The Adroit Journal* Djanikian Award Portfolio, Volume 45
2022 *Palette Poetry,* "Sand Flats, UT" 2022 (*Love and Eros Prize* Winner)
2022 *The Adroit Journal,* "Exorcism," "Past Tense," Volume 43, October 2022
2022 *Witness Magazine,* "Deinotherium Elegy," March 2022 (*Witness Literary Prize* Winner)
2021 *BOOTH Journal:* "Hosting," (Fiction)
2020 *Indiana Review*, "Coal Hollow Fire, UT" (*1/2 K Prize* Winner)
2020 *Sixth Finch,* "Primate Elegy," 2020
2020 *Waxwing,* "Playroom," "Panic Room," and "Map Room."
2019 *DIAGRAM*, "Between Stations."
2019 *THRUSH Poetry Journal,* "Darkroom."

Selected Awards and Grants

2024 Vanier Canada Graduate Scholarship, SSHRC, $150,000 CAD
2024 Annual Brian Laetz Graduate Essay Prize, University of British Columbia, $200 CAD
2022 President's Academic Excellence Initiative PhD Award, $10,000 CAD
2022 Four-Year Fellowship Award – The University of British Columbia, $88,000 CAD
2020 Connaught International Scholarship for Doctoral Students, The University of Toronto $50,000 CAD (Declined)
2017 Henry Hoyns Fellowship, The University of Virginia, $30,000 USD

Selected Poetry Awards

2023 Djanikian Scholarship, *Adroit Journal*
2022 Love and Eros Prize, *Palette Poetry,* $3,000 USD
2022 *Witness Magazine* Literary Award, $500 USD
2018 Indiana Review ½ K Prize for Nonfiction, *Indiana Review,* $1,000 USD

Presentations

Refereed Talks

2027 "Equal Love for All: Mysore Hiriyanna on Aesthetic Experience and Communal Feeling"
American Philosophical Association (APA) Pacific Division, Portland, OR

2026 "Macabre Visualization and Emotional Cultivation"
Buddhist Studies Unit, Topic: Buddhism and Meditation
American Academy of Religion (AAR) Annual Meeting in Denver, CO

2026 "From Disinterested Pleasure to Unitive Feeling: Three Neo-Rasa Takes"
The Canadian Philosophical Association (CPA) Annual Meeting, Halifax, NS

2025 "Aesthetic Emotion in Indian Renaissance Aesthetics"
Joint Session of the Aristotelian Society, Glasgow, Scotland, UK

2024 "Abhinavagupta and Two Puzzles About the Disgust *Rasa*"
American Society for Aesthetics (ASA) Annual Meeting, Chicago, IL

2023 "Towards a Cross-Disciplinary Approach to Poetic Meaning: *Rasadhvani* and the Heresy of Paraphrase Thesis," Hindu Philosophy Roundtable,
AAR Annual Meeting in San Antonio, TX

2023 "Doing Deathbed Aesthetics with K. C. Bhattacharyya"
ASA Pacific Division Meeting, Berkeley, CA

2023 "Daydreaming as Spontaneous Immersive Imagination"
Uehiro Graduate Philosophy Conference, University of Hawaii, Manoa, HI

2023 "Everyday Aesthetics and Deathbed Experiences,"
International Association of Japanese Philosophy (IAJP), Topic: Yuriko Saito
American Philosophical Association (APA) Central Division, Denver, CO

Invited Talks

2028 "The Place of Beauty in Rasa Theory." Jnanapravaha Mumbai Institute,
Lecture Series: Beauty in the Indian Aesthetic and Devotional Imagination,
Mumbai, MH, India

2027 "Death Denial and the Fog of Experience."
Mortal Feelings Conference, The University of Edinburgh, Scotland, UK

2027 "Aesthetic Shock and Emotional Insight: A. K. Coomaraswamy on *Saṁvega"*
Yale University, Numata Lecture Series in Buddhist Studies, New Haven, CT

2025 "Deathbed Aesthetics: Disgust and Courageous Love"
Simon Frasier University, Asian Philosophy Workshop, Burnaby, BC, Canada

2025 "Neo-Rasa: Expansive Empathy, Not Disinterest"
Symposium: South Asian *Rasa* Theory Meets Contemporary Aesthetics
APA Pacific Division, San Francisco, CA

2024 "*Rasa* and Negative Emotion"
Rasa 101, Rasa Fest, The University of British Columbia

2024 "Three Varieties of Immersive Imagination: Daydreaming, Fantasy, and Visualization"
Graduate Student Research Conference, The University of British Columbia

2023 "Introduction to K. C. Bhattacharyya's Aesthetics"
Graduate Aesthetics Seminar, University of California, Santa Cruz, CA

2022 "Courageous Love: K. C. Bhattacharyya and the Paradox of Painful Beauty,"
Workshop on K. C. Bhattacharyya, Smith College, Northampton, MA

Comments

2026 Book Panel: *Out of Sight, Into Mind* by Jed Forman
APA Central Division, Chicago, IL

2022 "Towards a Yogacāra-Informed Enactive Approach to Dreams,"
Author Meets Critics Session: Sonam Kachru, *Other Lives: Mind and World in Indian Buddhism*, AAR Annual Meeting, Denver, CO

2022 Author Meets Critics Session: James Reich, *To Savor the Meaning: The Theology of Literary Emotions in Medieval Kashmir.* ASA National Meeting, Portland, OR

Media & Public Philosophy

2027 Upcoming interview on *Polite Conversations* podcast with Brandon Polite

2027 Invited contribution to *New Work in Philosophy* on "Deathbed Aesthetics"

2027 Invited contribution to *Aesthetics for Birds* on the aesthetics of dying

2026 "Wasn't it Wisdom I Wanted? In Conversation with Emily Lawson," by Karan Kapoor, "Poet of the Week" Feature, *ONLY POEMS*

2024 "Meet Our Award Holders: Emily Lawson" The University of British Columbia

2023 "Interview with Emily Lawson" by A. T. Hincapie, *Palette Poetry*

2022 "Emily Lawson on Indian Philosophy, Death, and Imagination" *The Philosopher's Nest* Podcast, S1E9.

Teaching

Instructor

Sole instructor, responsible for class design, syllabus, teaching, and evaluation

University of British Columbia (Philosophy):

2026 Minds and Machines (PHIL 250)
2024 Philosophical Wisdom of Early India (PHIL/ASIA 375)

University of Virginia (English):

2020 Writing and Critical Inquiry: Writing about the Environment (ENWR 1510)
2020 Writing and Critical Inquiry: Harry Potter and the Ethical Imagination (ENWR 1510)
2019 Writing and Critical Inquiry: Harry Potter and the Ethical Imagination (ENWR 1510)
2019 Poetry Writing: Dream, Death, and Myth (ENCW 2300)
2019 Poetry Writing: Dream, Death, and Myth (ENCW 2300)
2018 Poetry Writing: Dream, Death, and Myth (ENCW 2300)

The University of Virginia (College Transition Program)

2019 Skills of Scholarship (LASE-3111)
With additional duties mentoring students and providing flexible academic support.

Teaching Assistant

Responsible for evaluation, student consultation, and guest lectures.

University of British Columbia:

2026 Philosophical Wisdom of Early India
2025 Philosophy of Mind
2025 Comparative Conceptions of the Self
2024 Philosophical Wisdom of Early India
2023 Existentialism
2023 Comparative Conceptions of the Self
2022 Philosophy of Religion
2023 Philosophy in the 17th Century
2022 Introduction to Moral Philosophy

Advising

University of British Columbia:

2025 Honours Student Thesis Advisor, Cognitive Systems Program
2024 Honours Student Thesis Advisor, Cognitive Systems Program

University of Virginia:

2019 Honours Student Thesis Advisor: Area Program in Poetry Writing
2018 Honours Student Thesis Advisor: Area Program in Poetry Writing

Service

Editing

2020 Editor-in-Chief, *Meridian: A Journal of Poetry and Prose from the University of Virginia*
2019 Nonfiction Editor, *Meridian: A Journal of Poetry and Prose from the University of Virginia*
2018 Poetry Reader, *Meridian: A Journal of Poetry and Prose from the University of Virginia*

Reviewing

Reviewer for: *Inquiry, Philosophy, Phenomenology and the Cognitive Sciences, Philosophy and the Mind Sciences, TOPOI*

Conference Organizing

2024 Steering Committee Member for Rasa 101 and Rasa Fest: South Asian Rasa Aesthetics in Contemporary Philosophy. The University of British Columbia.

Departmental Service

University of British Columbia:
2024 Graduate Student Representative: Department of Philosophy

University of Virginia:
2018 MFA Representative in the Graduate English Student Association

Memberships

The American Academy of Religion
The American Philosophical Association
The American Society for Aesthetics
The South Asian Comparative Philosophy Association
The Canadian Philosophical Association
The Association of Writers and Writing Programs

Languages

Classical Sanskrit – Advanced Reading and Translation, 10 years of study
Spanish – Intermediate
English – Native

Notable Language Training: Summer Intensive Sanskrit training in Pune, Maharashtra through the American Institute for Indian Studies (AIIS)

References

Evan Thompson, Professor of Philosophy and Distinguished University Scholar, University of British Columbia; Associate Member, Department of Asian Studies; Associate Member, Department of Psychology.

Dominic McIver Lopes, University Killam Professor of Philosophy, University of British Columbia

Catherine Prueitt, Assistant Professor of Philosophy, University of British Columbia.

Jay L. Garfield, Emeritus Doris Silbert Professor of Philosophy, Logic, and Buddhist Studies, Smith College; Emeritus Visiting Professor of Buddhist Philosophy, Harvard Divinity School; Emeritus Professor of Philosophy, University of Melbourne.

Kalina Christoff Hadjiilieva, Professor of Psychology, University of British Columbia

Sonam Kachru, Assistant Professor of Religious Studies, Yale University

Emine Hande Tuna, Associate Professor of Philosophy, University of California, Santa Cruz